

Word family: **decline / declines / declined / declining**

Base word: decline

Part of speech: mainly **verb** and **noun**

Related forms:

decline (v.) — 下降；減少；衰退；婉拒

decline (n.) — 下降；減少；衰退；沒落

declining (adj./participle) — 正在下降的；日漸衰退的

declined (participle) — 已下降的；已拒絕的

Useful expressions / extensions:

decline in

decline by

decline from A to B

decline sharply / gradually

declining motivation

declining sales

declining population

economic decline

a decline in quality

go into decline

fall into decline

reverse the decline

decline an invitation

decline an offer

decline to comment

politely decline

declining health

Meaning in this passage

> When diligent workers realise that their performance is being tied to colleagues who are less committed, motivation begins to **decline**.

Here, **decline** means:

to gradually become lower or weaker — 下降；減弱

The workers' motivation becomes weaker because they feel that the teamwork arrangement is unfair.

****中文翻譯：****

當勤奮的員工意識到自己的表現竟然與投入程度較低的同事掛鉤時，他們的動力便開始****下降 / 減弱****。

So here:

****motivation declines = 動力逐漸變弱、降低****

1. ****decline (下降；減少) — 下降；減少****

This is the exact sense used in your passage.

Practice 1 — original sentence

> Motivation begins to ****decline****.

工作動力開始****下降****。

Practice 2

> Productivity ****declined**** after several weeks of poor communication.

經過數星期的溝通不良後，生產力開始****下降****。

Practice 3

> Employee satisfaction has ****declined****.

員工滿意度已經****下降****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****decline = 數量、程度、水平或力量逐漸降低****

2. ****decline gradually — 逐漸下降****

Practice 1

> Motivation ****declined gradually**** over the course of the project.

隨着項目進行，員工動力****逐漸下降****。

Practice 2

> Sales have **declined gradually** over several years.

銷售額在數年間**逐步下降**。

MCQ-ready definition:

decline gradually = 經過一段時間慢慢下降

3. **decline sharply / rapidly** — 急劇下降

Practice 1

> Morale **declined sharply** after the announcement.

公布消息後，士氣**急劇下降**。

Practice 2

> Demand **declined rapidly**.

需求**迅速下降**。

MCQ-ready definition:

decline sharply/rapidly = 在短時間內明顯大幅下降

4. **decline in something** — 某方面的下降

A key noun pattern.

Practice 1

> There was a **decline in motivation**.

工作動力出現了**下降**。

Practice 2

> The company reported a **decline in sales**.

公司報告銷售額有所**下降**。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****a decline in X = X 的數量、水平、質素或程度下降****

5. ****decline by + amount — 下降了某個幅度****

Practice 1

> Sales ****declined by ten percent****.

銷售額****下降了百分之十****。

Practice 2

> Attendance ****declined by several hundred people****.

出席人數****減少了數百人****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****decline by X = 下降的幅度是 X****

6. ****decline from A to B — 從 A 降至 B****

Practice 1

> Attendance ****declined from 500 to 350****.

出席人數****由 500 人降至 350 人****。

Practice 2

> Satisfaction ****declined from 80% to 65%****.

滿意度****由百分之八十降至百分之六十五****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****decline from A to B = 由原本的 A 水平下降到 B****

7. ****declining sales / demand — 銷售 / 需求下跌****

Practice 1

> The company is worried about **declining sales**.

公司擔心**銷售額持續下跌**。

Practice 2

> **Declining demand** forced the factory to reduce production.

需求下降迫使工廠減產。

MCQ-ready definition:

declining X = X 正處於持續下降的狀態

8. **declining motivation / morale — 動力 / 士氣下降**

Very relevant to your paragraph.

Practice 1

> Unequal workloads can lead to **declining motivation**.

工作量不均可能導致**動力下降**。

Practice 2

> Managers need to address **declining morale** early.

管理人員需要及早處理**士氣下降**的問題。

MCQ-ready definition:

declining motivation/morale = 人們的投入、熱情或士氣逐漸減弱

9. **declining population — 人口下降**

Practice 1

> The town has a **declining population**.

這個城鎮的人口正在**下降**。

Practice 2

> A **declining population** can affect local services.

人口減少可能影響本地服務。

MCQ-ready definition:

declining population = 人口數量正在持續減少

10. **decline (質素 / 標準下降) — 下降 ; 變差**

A slightly broader qualitative branch.

Practice 1

> The quality of the work began to **decline**.

工作質素開始**下降 / 變差**。

Practice 2

> Standards have **declined** in recent years.

近年標準有所**下降**。

MCQ-ready definition:

decline = 質素、標準或表現逐漸變差

11. **a decline in quality / standards — 質素 / 標準下降**

Practice 1

> Customers noticed a **decline in service quality**.

顧客注意到服務質素**有所下降**。

Practice 2

> There has been a gradual **decline in standards**.

標準一直在**逐步下降**。

MCQ-ready definition:

****a decline in quality/standards = 原有質素或水平逐漸變差****

12. ****decline (健康 / 體力衰退) — 衰退 ; 變差****

Practice 1

> His health began to ****decline****.

他的健康開始****惡化 / 衰退****。

Practice 2

> Physical strength may ****decline**** with age.

體力可能隨年齡增長而****衰退****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****decline = 健康、體力或身體機能逐漸變弱****

13. ****declining health — 健康日益惡化****

Practice 1

> She reduced her workload because of ****declining health****.

她因****健康狀況日益轉差****而減少工作量。

Practice 2

> His ****declining health**** became a serious concern.

他的****健康衰退****成為嚴重問題。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****declining health = 健康狀況逐漸變差****

14. ****decline (權力 / 影響力衰落) — 衰退 ; 衰落****

A major historical/social sense.

Practice 1

> The organisation's influence began to **decline**.

這個組織的影響力開始**衰退**。

Practice 2

> The empire **declined** over several centuries.

這個帝國在數個世紀間逐漸**衰落**。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****decline = 權力、影響力、重要性或地位逐漸減弱****

15. **economic decline — 經濟衰退**

Practice 1

> The region experienced prolonged **economic decline**.

該地區經歷了長期的**經濟衰退**。

Practice 2

> Factory closures accelerated the town's **economic decline**.

工廠倒閉加快了城鎮的**經濟衰退**。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****economic decline = 經濟活動、收入、投資或就業等長期轉弱****

16. **the decline of an industry / institution — 行業 / 機構的衰落**

Practice 1

> The book examines the **decline of the newspaper industry**.

這本書探討報業的**衰落**。

Practice 2

> Several factors contributed to the **decline of the organisation**.

多個因素促成了該組織的**衰退**。

MCQ-ready definition:

the decline of X = X 的力量、重要性、規模或成功程度逐步減弱

17. **go into decline — 開始衰退**

Practice 1

> The area **went into decline** after the factory closed.

工廠關閉後，該區開始**衰落**。

Practice 2

> Without investment, the business may **go into decline**.

如果沒有投資，業務可能會**逐步衰退**。

MCQ-ready definition:

go into decline = 開始進入持續變差或衰退的時期

18. **fall into decline — 陷入衰退**

Practice 1

> The building **fell into decline** after years of neglect.

這棟建築因多年缺乏保養而**日漸破敗**。

Practice 2

> The town **fell into decline** after losing its main industry.

城鎮在失去主要產業後**陷入衰退**。

MCQ-ready definition:

fall into decline = 逐漸陷入破敗、衰弱或不景氣狀態

19. **reverse / halt a decline — 扭轉 / 阻止衰退**

Practice 1

> The company introduced changes to **reverse the decline in sales**.

公司推出改革，希望**扭轉銷售下跌**。

Practice 2

> Strong leadership helped **halt the decline in morale**.

良好領導有助**阻止士氣繼續下降**。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****reverse/halt a decline = 令下降停止，甚至重新上升****

20. **decline something (拒絕) — 婉拒；拒絕接受**

A completely separate major verb sense.

Practice 1

> She **declined the invitation**.

她**婉拒了邀請**。

Practice 2

> He **declined the offer**.

他**拒絕了這個提議 / 邀請**。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****decline something = 禮貌或正式地表示不接受某物****

21. **decline an invitation — 婉拒邀請**

Practice 1

> I had to **decline the invitation** because of a prior commitment.

我因早已有安排，只好**婉拒邀請**。

Practice 2

> She politely **declined the invitation**.

她有禮貌地**謝絕邀請**。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****decline an invitation = 禮貌表示不出席或不接受邀請****

22. ****decline an offer — 拒絕提議 / 工作邀請****

Practice 1

> He **declined the job offer**.

他**拒絕了工作邀請**。

Practice 2

> She decided to **decline their offer**.

她決定**婉拒對方的提議**。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****decline an offer = 正式或禮貌表示不接受某個提議****

23. ****decline a request — 拒絕要求****

Practice 1

> The manager **declined the request**.

經理**拒絕了這項要求**。

Practice 2

> The application may be **declined** if information is missing.

如果資料不完整，申請可能會被**拒絕**。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****decline a request/application = 正式決定不批准或不接受****

24. ****decline to do something — 拒絕做某事****

A key grammar pattern.

Practice 1

> He ****declined to comment****.

他****拒絕置評****。

Practice 2

> She ****declined to answer the question****.

她****拒絕回答問題****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****decline to do X = 禮貌、正式或刻意地拒絕做 X****

25. ****decline to comment — 拒絕置評****

A very common formal phrase.

Practice 1

> The company ****declined to comment**** on the report.

公司對報告****拒絕置評****。

Practice 2

> He was asked about the incident but ****declined to comment****.

有人問他關於事件的問題，但他****拒絕評論****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****decline to comment = 正式表示不願就某事發表意見****

26. **politely / respectfully decline** — 禮貌 / 恭敬地婉拒

Practice 1

> She **politely declined** the invitation.

她**有禮貌地婉拒**了邀請。

Practice 2

> I must **respectfully decline**.

我必須**恭敬地婉拒**。

MCQ-ready definition:

politely/respectfully decline = 以有禮、較正式的方式拒絕

27. **decline** (noun : 下降) — 下降 ; 減少

Practice 1

> There has been a **decline in motivation**.

工作動力有所**下降**。

Practice 2

> The company reported a **sharp decline in profits**.

公司報告利潤**大幅下降**。

MCQ-ready definition:

a decline = 數量、程度、質素或力量的下降

28. **sharp / steady / gradual decline** — 急劇 / 持續 / 逐步下降

Practice 1

> Sales showed a **sharp decline**.

銷售額出現**急劇下降**。

Practice 2

> There has been a **steady decline in attendance**.

出席人數一直**穩步下降**。

MCQ-ready definition:

X decline = 用不同形容詞表示下降的速度和模式

29. **decline (noun : 衰退 ; 沒落) — 衰退 ; 衰落**

Practice 1

> The industry has been in **decline** for years.

這個行業多年來一直處於**衰退**。

Practice 2

> The town's **decline** began after the mine closed.

礦場關閉後，城鎮開始**衰落**。

MCQ-ready definition:

decline = 地位、力量、繁榮、健康或質素長期變弱的過程

30. **in decline — 正在衰退**

Practice 1

> The industry is **in decline**.

這個行業正在**衰退**。

Practice 2

> Membership has been **in decline** for several years.

會員人數已經連續數年**下降**。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****be in decline = 正處於持續下降或衰弱的狀態****

Important distinction 1: ****decline vs decrease****

****decrease****

neutral numerical or quantitative reduction.

****decline****

often suggests downward movement over time and can apply to:

- * numbers,
- * quality,
- * health,
- * influence,
- * motivation.

> Prices decreased by 5%.

> 價格下降百分之五。

> Morale declined.

> 士氣下降。

****Decline**** is broader and often more gradual/process-oriented.

Important distinction 2: ****decline vs drop****

****drop****

often suggests a quicker or more noticeable decrease and is more conversational.

****decline****

more formal and often gradual.

> Sales dropped suddenly.

> 銷售突然下跌。

> Sales declined over several years.

> 銷售在幾年間持續下降。

Important distinction 3: **decline vs fall**

fall

very broad downward movement.

decline

often implies a trend over time, especially:

- * performance,
- * health,
- * quality,
- * importance.

> temperature fell
> 氣溫下降

> standards declined
> 標準下降

Important distinction 4: **decline vs deteriorate**

decline

become lower/weaker.

deteriorate

become worse in condition or quality.

> sales decline
> 銷售下降

> building condition deteriorates
> 建築狀況惡化

For health, both can work:

> health declined
> health deteriorated

but **deteriorate** emphasizes worsening condition more strongly.

Important distinction 5: **decline vs weaken**

weaken

lose strength.

decline

broader downward trend.

> support weakened

> 支持力度減弱

> support declined

> 支持度下降

Important distinction 6: **decline vs refuse**

A major polysemy distinction.

decline

more polite/formal refusal.

refuse

directly say no; stronger and broader.

> decline an invitation

> 婉拒邀請

> refuse to cooperate

> 拒絕合作

So:

decline often sounds softer and more formal

Important distinction 7: **decline vs reject**

decline

usually polite/formal and often about:

- * invitation,
- * offer,
- * request.

reject

stronger; judge something unacceptable or refuse it.

- > decline a job offer
- > 婉拒工作邀請

- > reject an application
- > 拒絕 / 否決申請

There is overlap in institutional contexts.

Important distinction 8: **decline vs turn down**

decline

formal.

turn down

common conversational phrasal verb.

- > decline an invitation
- > 婉拒邀請

- > turn down an invitation
- > 拒絕邀請

Same broad result, different register.

Important distinction 9: **decline + noun vs decline to + verb**

Noun:

> decline the offer

Infinitive:

> decline to comment

Not:

> *decline commenting* ❌ for the normal refusal sense.

Important distinction 10: **decline in vs decline of**

a decline in X

X itself becomes lower.

> a decline in sales

> 銷售下降

the decline of X

X as a whole loses power, status, importance, etc.

> the decline of an empire

> 帝國的衰落

Excellent grammar + meaning distinction.

Important distinction 11: **decline by vs decline to**

Amount:

> declined **by 20%**

> 下降了百分之二十

New level:

> declined **to 20%**

> 下降至百分之二十

Very important MCQ distinction.

Important distinction 12: ****decline from A to B****

This gives both starting and ending levels:

> declined from 80 to 60

= ****由 80 降至 60****

Do not confuse with:

> declined by 60

which describes the amount of change.

Important distinction 13: ****declining motivation vs lost motivation****

****declining motivation****

motivation is progressively becoming weaker.

****lost motivation****

motivation may already be largely gone.

Your passage uses ****begins to decline****, emphasizing the ****start of a downward process****.

Important distinction 14: ****decline vs collapse****

****decline****

gradual or sustained downward movement.

****collapse****

sudden, severe failure or fall.

> morale declined

> 士氣下降

> morale collapsed

> 士氣崩潰

Much stronger.

Important distinction 15: ****decline in your passage****

Here, it is not:

- * refusing an invitation,
- * a historical empire collapsing,
- * a medical condition deteriorating.

It simply means:

****workers gradually become less motivated****

The process matters:

> unfairness appears → resentment grows → motivation ****declines****

Family-extension note

****Decline**** has two major modern semantic branches:

1. ****become lower / weaker****

- * motivation declines
- * sales decline
- * health declines
- * an industry declines

This expands into:

- * quantitative decrease,
- * quality deterioration,
- * health deterioration,
- * loss of power/status.

2. ****refuse politely/formally****

- * decline an invitation
- * decline an offer
- * decline to comment

The noun then covers:

3. **downward change**

- * a decline in sales

4. **longer-term deterioration**

- * economic decline
- * an industry in decline

For your passage, the exact branch is:

decline = become progressively weaker or lower

Master comparison

Form / expression	Traditional Chinese	Core idea
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decline (verb)	下降；減少	become lower
motivation declines	動力下降	weaker motivation
decline gradually	逐漸下降	slow reduction
decline sharply	急劇下降	large reduction
decline by X	下降 X	amount changed
decline from A to B	從 A 降至 B	start/end
declining sales	銷售下降	business
declining population	人口下降	demographics
decline in quality	質素下降	deterioration
health declines	健康衰退	physical condition
influence declines	影響力衰退	status/power
economic decline	經濟衰退	economy
the decline of X	X 的衰落	long-term weakening
go into decline	開始衰退	enter decline
fall into decline	陷入衰退 / 破敗	deterioration
reverse a decline	扭轉下降	recovery
decline an invitation	婉拒邀請	polite refusal
decline an offer	拒絕提議	formal refusal
decline a request	拒絕要求	formal refusal
decline to comment	拒絕置評	formal refusal

politely decline	禮貌婉拒	register	
a decline in X	X 的下降	noun decrease	
sharp decline	急跌	large fall	
decline (noun)	衰退；衰落	deterioration	
in decline	正在衰退	ongoing weakening	

For your original sentence

> When diligent workers realise that their performance is being tied to colleagues who are less committed, motivation begins to **decline**.

Here:

motivation begins to decline = 勤奮員工原本的投入和積極性開始逐漸減弱，因為他們覺得自己的努力沒有得到公平反映

A natural Traditional Chinese rendering is:

> 當勤奮的員工意識到自己的表現竟然與投入程度較低的同事掛鉤時，他們的工作動力便開始**下降**。

The cleanest contrast is:

> **decrease** = 一般數量下降

> **drop** = 較口語，常帶較突然的下降感

> **deteriorate** = 狀況 / 質素惡化

> **decline** = **數量、質素、力量、健康或動力逐步變弱 / 下降**

For this passage, **decline** is especially natural because the writer is describing a **gradual erosion of motivation**, not an instant loss of it.